

Louisiana Constitutional Amendments

May 2026 Ballot Analysis

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Prepared for: Thad

Disclaimer: This report provides research-based analysis and recommendations based on publicly available information. Voting decisions are deeply personal and should align with your values, principles, and prayerful consideration. This is not legal, financial, or political advice.

Executive Summary

This report analyzes the five statewide constitutional amendments on Louisiana's May 16, 2026 ballot, plus two Tangipahoa Parish Home Rule Charter amendments. The analysis considers Christian values, principles of good governance, fiscal responsibility, and respect for existing systems.

Key Themes Across Amendments:

- Amendment 1: Civil service employment protections
- Amendment 2: St. George school district authority
- Amendment 3: Teacher pay raises via pension debt reduction
- Amendment 4: Business inventory property tax exemptions
- Amendment 5: Judicial retirement age extension

The recommendations below reflect careful consideration of each measure's impact on families, communities, workers, and the state's long-term governance structure.

Amendment 1: Civil Service Employment (SB 8)

What it does: Currently only the Louisiana State Civil Service Commission can designate positions as 'unclassified' (at-will employment without civil service protections). This amendment would allow the Legislature to also add or remove unclassified positions by passing laws.

Background: Louisiana has strong civil service protections rooted in reforms following the 'Louisiana Hayride' scandals of 1939. About 13% of state employees are currently unclassified. The constitution currently lists specific unclassified positions (elected officials, department heads, higher education staff, etc.) and allows the Civil Service Commission to add more via rules.

Key Concerns:

- Opens door to politicization of state employment (historically called the 'spoils system')
- Removes neutral Civil Service Commission as gatekeeper
- Unclassified employees can participate in political activities; classified cannot
- Potential for targeted dismissal of specific employees by legislative action
- No comprehensive study was done before proposing this sweeping change

Amendment 1

Recommendation: VOTE NO

This amendment risks returning Louisiana to the era of political patronage where state jobs become rewards for political loyalty rather than merit-based positions. The existing system, while sometimes criticized for being rigid, exists to protect workers from arbitrary political dismissal. The legislature already has significant control over state government; giving them direct power to strip employment protections creates risks for workers and invites corruption. Scripture warns about unjust scales and favoritism (Proverbs 11:1, James 2).

Amendment 2: St. George School District (SB 25)

What it does: Grants the St. George Community School System (in East Baton Rouge Parish) the same authority as parishes regarding Article VII, Section 13 of the Constitution-including access to Minimum Foundation Program (MFP)

funding for school books, instructional materials, and the ability to raise local revenues for schools.

Background: St. George is a newly formed municipality in East Baton Rouge Parish that incorporated following years of tension with the parish school system. This amendment is part of a settlement to resolve the long-running conflict between St. George and East Baton Rouge Parish schools. The amendment essentially treats St. George as equivalent to a parish for educational funding purposes.

Considerations:

- Local control of education aligns with family and community values
- Resolves ongoing legal/political conflict through democratic process
- Allows St. George to manage its own tax revenues for schools
- Creates precedent for other municipalities seeking similar arrangements

Amendment 2

Recommendation: VOTE YES

Local control of education allows communities to better align schooling with their values and priorities. St. George residents voted to incorporate and create their own school system; this amendment simply gives them the same constitutional authority other parishes have to fund and operate those schools. Respecting local democratic decisions and reducing centralized control aligns with principles of subsidiarity-addressing issues at the most local level possible. Deuteronomy 6 emphasizes parents' role in teaching children, which local school control can better support.

Amendment 3: Teacher Pay Raises (HB 473)

What it does: Funds a \$2,250 teacher pay raise and \$1,125 support staff pay raise by using remaining savings from paying down the Teachers' Retirement System of Louisiana (TRSL) debt. The amendment repeals certain constitutional funds and redirects that money to the unfunded accrued liability (UAL) of the teacher pension system, with the 'savings' from reduced pension payments going to salaries.

Background: Louisiana has struggled with teacher retention, partly due to low pay relative to neighboring states. The Teachers' Retirement System has significant unfunded liabilities. This approach attempts to use debt reduction 'savings' to fund raises rather than new taxes.

Key Concerns:

- The mechanism is complex-using pension debt payment 'savings' for current salaries
- Eliminates certain constitutional education funds permanently
- Raises are modest (\$2,250 for teachers, \$1,125 for support staff)
- Doesn't address structural underfunding of education long-term
- Effectively redirects dedicated funds to general operations

Amendment 3

Recommendation: VOTE YES

Teachers deserve fair compensation for their vital work in shaping the next generation. While the mechanism is imperfect-essentially robbing Peter (pension funds) to pay Paul (current salaries)-the outcome supports educators who are called to serve families and children. Scripture affirms the laborer is worthy of his wages (1 Timothy 5:18). Louisiana teachers are underpaid compared to regional peers, affecting retention and quality. However, this should be viewed as a temporary fix; the state needs a sustainable, long-term plan for competitive teacher compensation rather than complex accounting maneuvers.

Amendment 4: Business Inventory Tax Exemption (HB 366)

What it does: Allows parishes to reduce or completely exempt business inventory from property taxes. This includes property held to sell and property held for use in producing goods for sale. Currently, Louisiana taxes business inventory like many other states.

Background: Louisiana is one of only 9 states that fully taxes business inventory (along with Arkansas, Kentucky, Maryland, Mississippi, Oklahoma, Texas, Virginia, and West Virginia). The business community argues this discourages companies from maintaining inventory in Louisiana and puts the state at a competitive disadvantage for economic development.

Considerations:

- Could make Louisiana more competitive for businesses
- Shifts tax burden from businesses to other property owners
- Local parishes lose revenue that funds schools, roads, public safety
- Benefits larger businesses with significant inventory more than small businesses
- Creates patchwork of exemptions across parishes if adopted unevenly

Amendment 4

Recommendation: VOTE NO

While making Louisiana business-competitive is laudable, this amendment shifts the tax burden from corporations to homeowners and other property owners. It reduces revenue for local schools and services without any guarantee that businesses will reinvest those savings in Louisiana workers or communities. The 'trickle down' approach has historically favored wealthy interests over working families. Proverbs 22:16 warns against giving to the rich. True economic development should focus on creating good jobs and building communities, not tax giveaways that weaken local governments' ability to serve residents.

Amendment 5: Judicial Retirement Age (HB 63)

What it does: Changes the mandatory retirement age for judges from 70 to 75 years old. Judges who reach age 70 while serving a term could already complete that term; this amendment allows them to serve until age 75 and seek re-election if their term extends past 70.

Background: Louisiana's judicial retirement age hasn't been updated in decades despite increased life expectancy and longer careers. Supporters argue experienced judges provide valuable institutional knowledge. Critics argue mandatory retirement ensures judicial turnover and brings fresh perspectives to the bench.

Considerations:

- Experience matters in judicial decision-making
- Longer tenures reduce opportunities for new judges to enter the system
- Louisiana has a large judicial system-more judges than many peer states
- Some studies suggest cognitive decline can affect judicial performance in later years
- The change is modest (5 years) and allows voters to still choose

Amendment 5

Recommendation: VOTE NO

While experience is valuable, mandatory retirement ages serve important purposes: they ensure regular turnover, bring fresh perspectives to the judiciary, and provide natural opportunities for accountability through elections. Louisiana already has a sprawling judicial system; extending terms reduces opportunities for qualified new judges to serve. Additionally, research shows cognitive decline can affect decision-making in later years-a concern for those interpreting laws that affect citizens' lives and liberties. The current system strikes a reasonable balance. Ecclesiastes 3 teaches there is a time for everything, including seasons of service and seasons of rest.

Tangipahoa Parish Home Rule Charter Amendments

PW HRC Amendment No. 1 of 2:

Amends Article II, Section 2-01(A) to limit Parish Council members to four (4) consecutive four-year terms.

PW HRC Amendment No. 2 of 2:

Amends Article III, Section 3-02 to limit the Parish President to four (4) consecutive four-year terms.

These amendments would establish term limits for Tangipahoa Parish elected officials, similar to term limits in place in many other Louisiana parishes and statewide offices. Currently, parish council members and the parish president can serve unlimited terms.

Arguments for term limits:

- Prevents entrenched power and political dynasties
- Brings fresh ideas and perspectives to local government
- Reduces advantages of incumbency in elections
- Encourages citizen participation by opening seats

Arguments against term limits:

- Removes experienced leaders who know the system
- Voters already have the power to replace officials through elections
- Can empower unelected staff and special interests who remain while elected officials rotate

Amendment Parish Amendments 1 & 2

Recommendation: VOTE YES

Term limits are a healthy check on political power concentration. While experience matters, indefinite tenure often leads to complacency, reduced accountability, and entrenchment of political networks. Four terms (16 years) is generous enough to allow significant service while ensuring regular turnover. This aligns with the biblical wisdom that power should not concentrate indefinitely in human hands (Deuteronomy 17:14-20, which includes term-like limits on kings). Fresh perspectives in local government benefit the community and encourage broader participation.

Voting Summary

Recommended Votes:

Amendment 1 (Civil Service)	NO	Risks politicizing state employment
Amendment 2 (St. George Schools)	YES	Supports local control of education
Amendment 3 (Teacher Raises)	YES	Honors teachers' vital work
Amendment 4 (Business Tax Cut)	NO	Shifts burden from businesses to residents
Amendment 5 (Judge Retirement)	NO	Maintains healthy judicial turnover
Parish Amendment 1 (Council Term Limits)	YES	Prevents power entrenchment
Parish Amendment 2 (President Term Limits)	YES	Prevents power entrenchment

Final Note: These recommendations are based on research and analysis, but your vote should ultimately reflect your own values, conscience, and prayerful consideration. Scripture calls us to be wise stewards and to seek justice. As you vote, consider not just immediate effects but long-term consequences for workers, families, communities, and future generations. Pray for wisdom (James 1:5), and vote accordingly.

Sources & Further Reading

- Leaders for a Better Louisiana - Constitutional Amendments Analysis
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